How to read this leave-behind: one decision, the evidence for it, and its limits

Standalone leave-behind of the Q2 2026 business review, written to be read without a presenter

PURPOSE

This review compares Northstar Cloud's Q2 2026 results with the Q1 2026 actuals and the Q2 2026 plan. It asks the executive team for one decision before the Q3 plan is signed off.

DECISION REQUESTED

Do not assume Q3 plan recovery until pipeline-stage, retention and scenario evidence is reviewed. Three functions own one evidence request each.

ORDER OF THE PAGES

Answer, summary, revenue, gross profit, scorecard, pipeline risk, options, decision, data notes.

HOW TO READ THE STATUS WORDS

Ahead of plan / Short of plan: status against the Q2 2026 plan, in words and in colour (green, red).

Implied: a derived figure that rests on a stated assumption.

RECOMMENDATION: a judgement on the evidence, not a verified finding.

Unknown: the source holds no data for it, so no figure is shown.

Synthetic data: every figure comes from one synthetic CSV for a fictional company.

Q2 revenue grew 14.3% but reached 96% of plan; pipeline coverage closed the least of its gap

Growth was real, but only gross margin reached plan, so a Q3 recovery is not yet shown.

REVENUE, Q2 2026

$4.8M

+14.3% vs Q1

96% of $5.0M plan

GROSS MARGIN, Q2 2026

74%

+1 pp vs plan

The only metric ahead of plan

PIPELINE COVERAGE, Q2 2026

2.9x

−0.3x vs 3.2x plan

Closed 40% of its gap to plan

Decision requested: do not assume Q3 plan recovery until pipeline-stage, retention, and scenario evidence is reviewed.

The options and three evidence requests with owners close the deck.

Definitions. Plan: the Q2 2026 plan. pp: percentage points. x: pipeline coverage multiple. Gap closed: the share of the gap between Q1 2026 actual and Q2 2026 plan that Q2 covered.

Source: quarterly_metrics.csv (synthetic); growth, attainment and gap closure are calculated from it.

Growth is real but slower than planned, and the forward indicators are short of plan

The gain is real, the plan miss is in its size, and the forward indicators also trail plan.

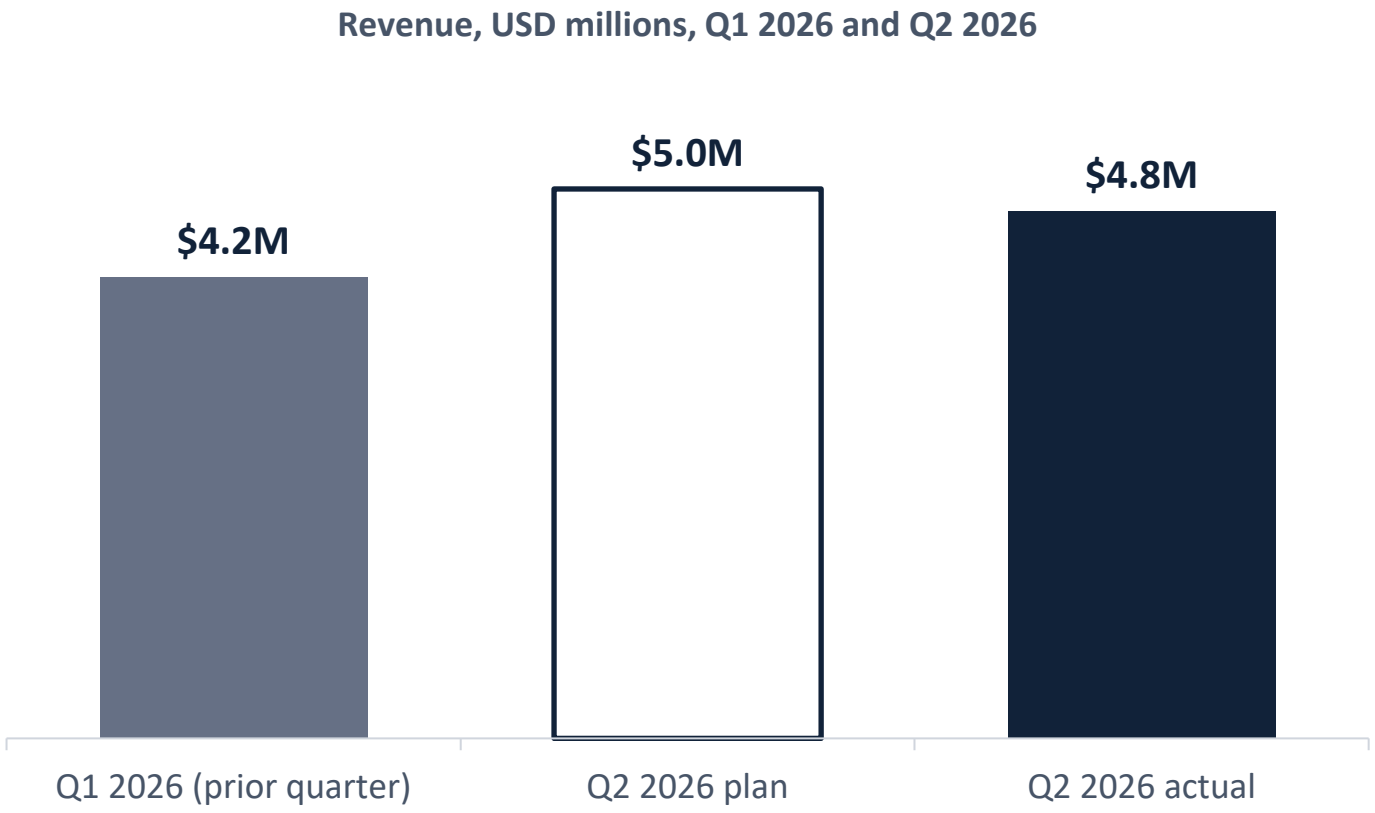
1 Growth is slower than planned	Revenue rose $0.6M (+14.3%) on Q1. The plan required +19.0%. Q2 delivered 75% of the planned increase.
2 Margin beat plan; gross-profit dollars did not	Gross margin was 1 pp ahead of plan. Implied gross profit was $0.10M below plan, because revenue fell short.
3 Forward indicators are short of plan	Pipeline coverage closed 40% of its gap to plan. Net revenue retention was 108% against a 110% plan.

No metric in this deck establishes a cause. Possible drivers, such as deal timing, product mix or a plan set too high, are hypotheses until segment, pipeline and plan-method data are reviewed.

Source: quarterly_metrics.csv (synthetic); changes, gap closure and implied gross profit are calculated (implied gross profit is derived).

Revenue grew $0.6M but finished $0.2M (–4.0%) below plan

Revenue rose on Q1 but delivered only part of the increase that the plan required.



PLAN ATTAINMENT

96.0%

GROWTH REQUIRED BY PLAN

+19.0% on Q1

GROWTH DELIVERED

+14.3% on Q1

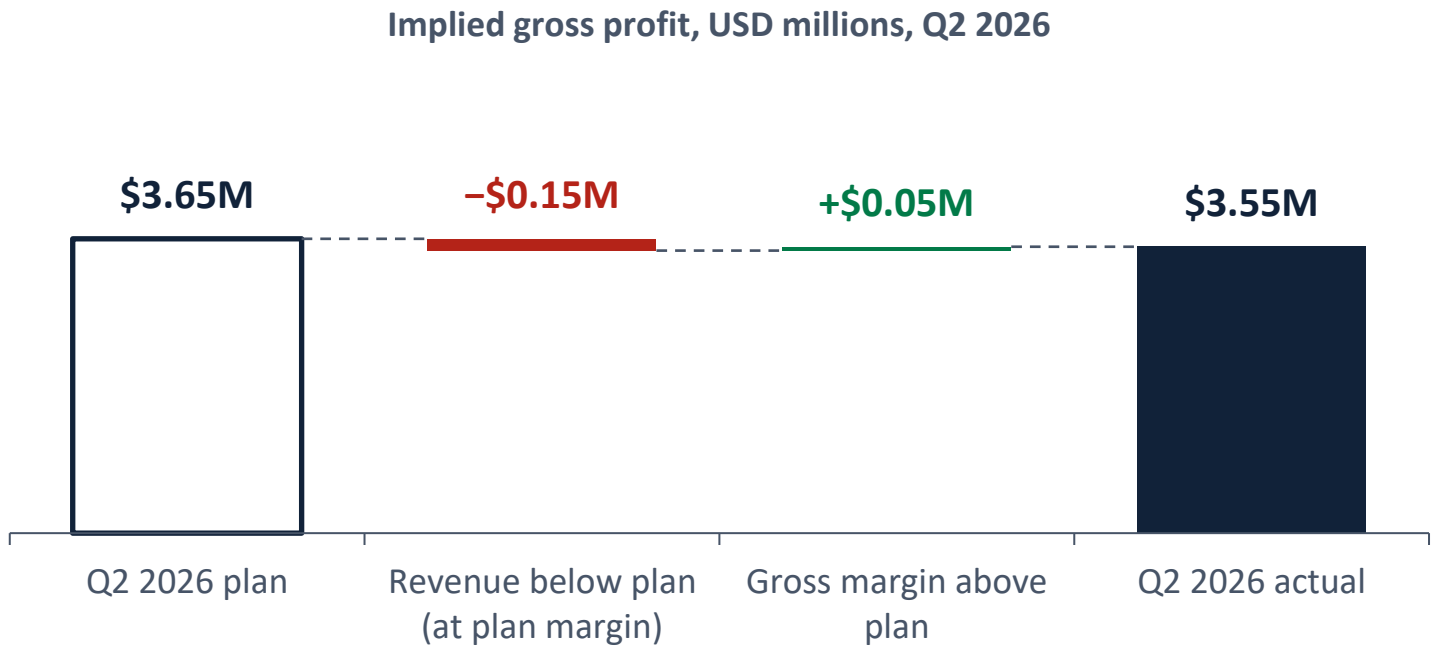
Q2 delivered 75% of the planned increase. The miss is a smaller gain, not a decline.

The plan method is not stated, so the miss may reflect the plan as well as performance.

Source: quarterly_metrics.csv (synthetic), Revenue row; attainment and growth are calculated from it.

Margin beat plan, but implied gross profit was $0.10M below plan

The margin beat added less than the revenue shortfall cost, so implied gross profit missed plan.



HOW TO READ THE BRIDGE

Plan $3.65M, less the revenue shortfall at plan margin ($0.15M), plus the margin gain on actual revenue ($0.05M), gives actual $3.55M.

Gross margin 74% vs 73% plan. Net variance −2.7% of plan gross profit.

Q1 $3.02M (+17.5% in Q2).

Derived figure. Implied gross profit = revenue × gross margin. The source does not state the gross-margin basis; these figures assume it applies to reported revenue. Operating cost and profit are not in the source. Axis starts at zero.

Source: quarterly_metrics.csv (synthetic), Revenue and Gross_Margin rows; implied gross profit is derived from them.

Every metric improved on Q1, but only gross margin reached plan

All seven metrics improved on Q1, yet six of them stayed short of plan.

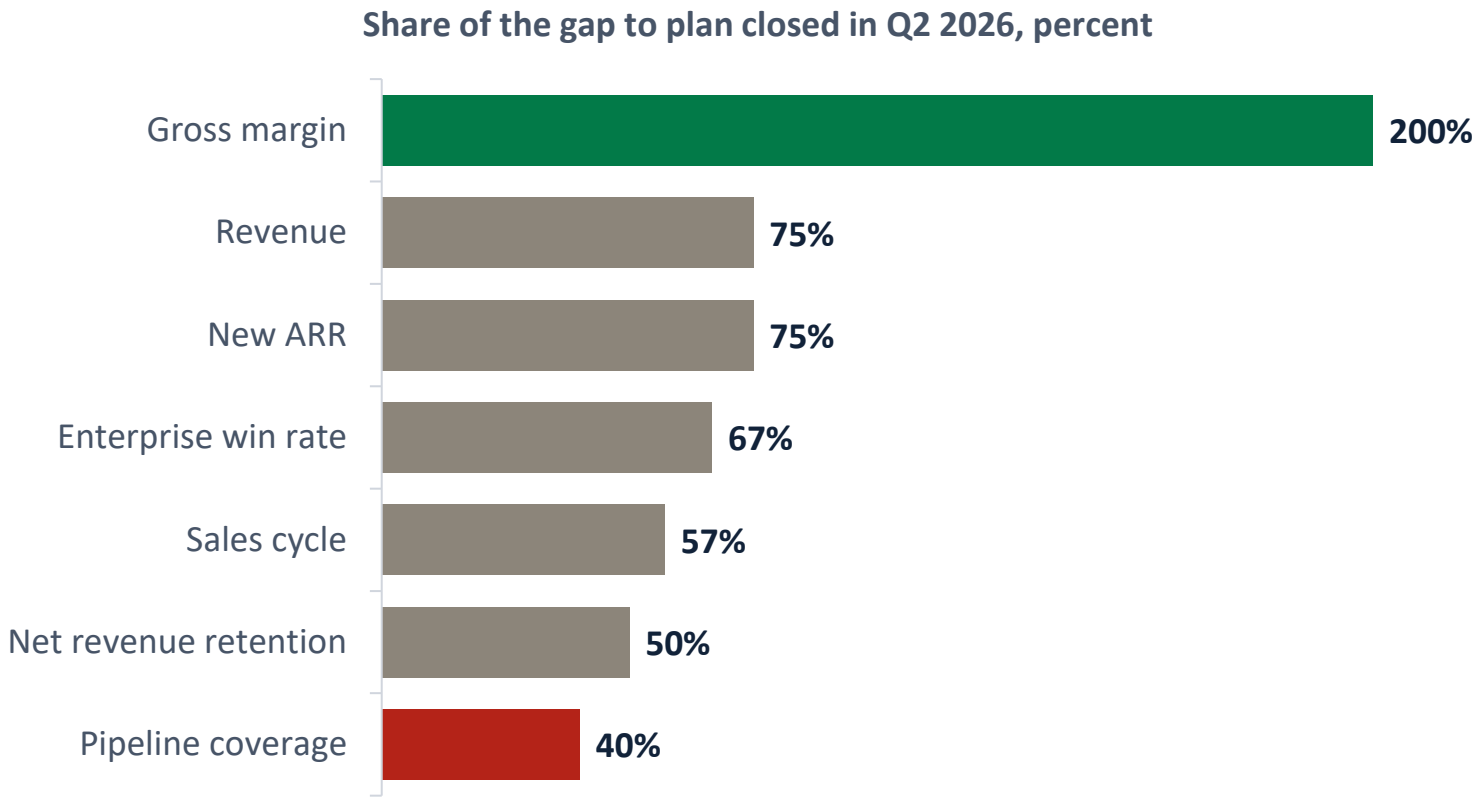
Metric	Q1 2026	Q2 2026	Q2 plan	Change vs Q1	Variance vs plan	Status
Revenue	$4.2M	**$4.8M**	$5.0M	+$0.6M	**–$0.2M**	**Short of plan**
New ARR	$1.1M	**$1.4M**	$1.5M	+$0.3M	**–$0.1M**	**Short of plan**
Gross margin	72%	**74%**	73%	+2 pp	**+1 pp**	**Ahead of plan**
Net revenue retention	106%	**108%**	110%	+2 pp	**–2 pp**	**Short of plan**
Pipeline coverage	2.7x	**2.9x**	3.2x	+0.2x	**–0.3x**	**Short of plan**
Enterprise win rate	24%	**28%**	30%	+4 pp	**–2 pp**	**Short of plan**
Sales cycle	67 days	**63 days**	60 days	–4 days	**+3 days**	**Short of plan**

pp = percentage points; x = coverage multiple. For sales cycle, fewer days is ahead of plan. Status is shown in words as well as colour. The win-rate population and the sales-cycle averaging method are not stated.

Source: quarterly_metrics.csv (synthetic), all seven metric rows; change and variance are calculated from them.

Pipeline coverage closed only 40% of its gap to plan, the lowest of the seven metrics

Coverage closed the least of its gap, which matters for Q3 if it measures future-quarter pipeline.



HOW TO READ

100% means Q2 reached plan. Gross margin passed plan.

PIPELINE COVERAGE

2.9x vs 3.2x plan (90.6% attainment)

Of the seven metrics, coverage closed the smallest share of its gap. This is a rank, not a forecast; the coverage basis is not stated. If coverage measures pipeline for future quarters, the shortfall matters for Q3. The source does not show how well coverage predicts revenue.

Source: quarterly_metrics.csv (synthetic); gap closed = (Q2 actual − Q1 actual) ÷ (Q2 plan − Q1 actual).

Signing off the Q3 plan now would assume Q3 reaches plan, which the Q2 data does not yet show

Signing off now is faster but assumes Q3 reaches plan; reviewing first adds an unknown delay.

Tradeoff	Option A: sign off the Q3 plan now	Option B: review the evidence first
Assumes	Q3 reaches plan where Q2 fell short, although Q2 reached plan on one metric of seven. The Q3 plan is not in the source.	The three evidence requests can be answered before the Q3 plan is signed off.
Gains	The Q3 plan is set at once, with no wait for new analysis.	The Q3 plan is set with pipeline, retention and scenario evidence in hand.
Risks	Another plan miss if the Q2 shortfalls continue: coverage and retention are both short of plan.	Sign-off waits for three outputs, and the source sets no date for them.
Cost	Unknown. The source holds no cost data.	Unknown. The source holds no cost or effort data for the requests.

RECOMMENDATION: review the evidence first (option B), then sign off the Q3 plan.

The options and tradeoffs are a RECOMMENDATION drawn from the Q2 evidence on the earlier slides, not a verified finding. Neither option has a cost estimate, because the source holds no cost or effort data.

Source: Q2 2026 evidence on the revenue, gross profit, scorecard and pipeline slides; the source holds no cost data.

Before Q3 plan sign-off, leadership needs three pieces of evidence

Three functions each bring one piece of evidence, and the executive team assigns the work now.

Decision requested: agree that Q3 plan recovery is not assumed until these three outputs are reviewed.

Next action: the executive team assigns the three requests below to their functions.

Owner (function)	Next action	Why it matters	Trigger in Q2 data
Sales Operations	Run a pipeline audit by stage, age, and segment	Shows whether coverage can support the Q3 plan.	Pipeline coverage short of plan
Customer Success	Build a retention bridge by cohort: expansion, contraction, churn	Shows how much of the retention change is expansion, contraction and churn.	Net revenue retention short of plan
Finance	Build a Q3 scenario range from Q2 actual gap closure	Gives a first Q3 range, based on one quarter (Q2) of gap closure.	Revenue growth slower than plan
CEO and executive team	Assign the three requests and agree when the outputs are reviewed	Turns the decision into owned work.	The decision requested above

These are proposals for a fictional company. They are not commitments or verified root causes. Owners are functions, not named people, and the source sets no dates.

Source: Q2 2026 findings on pipeline coverage, retention and revenue growth; the source names no people and sets no dates.

These figures show Q2 results against plan but cannot show causes, a forecast or a business case

Read every figure with the limits below; four narrative steps are left out for lack of evidence.

SOURCE AND EVIDENCE TRAIL

One synthetic CSV: seven metrics, Q1 2026 actual, Q2 2026 actual, Q2 2026 plan. Every slide figure traces to a source cell or a calculation in the claims register. Evidence trail: source CSV, data validation, business assessment, claims register, this deck. The deck and its claims register are in the public portfolio repository; the source data and the validation workings are private.

CONVENTIONS

Growth and attainment of dollar metrics are percentages (plan, pp and x: see the glossary). Value labels are rounded to the precision shown; gap-closed labels to whole percents. Bridge steps look thin because the axis starts at zero.

LIMITATIONS

No segment, product or customer data, so no driver or segment conclusion. Two actual quarters and one plan period, so no trend or forecast-accuracy view. Retention cohort, pipeline basis and gross-margin basis are not defined. Implied gross profit is a derived figure that needs an assumption.

OMITTED NARRATIVE STEPS AND WHY

Step	Why it is omitted
Cost of inaction	The CSV has no Q3 data, so no projection is made; the Q2 gaps stay as facts on the revenue and profit slides.
Market insight	One synthetic CSV with no market or peer data. The external buyer-research claims in this project concern B2B buying, not this company, so they are not used.
Proof	No evidence yet shows that the three requests work.
Business case	No cost or benefit data exists, so an ROI figure would be invented.

Merged, not omitted: future state (growth required by plan, on the revenue slide) and implementation (owners and outputs, on the decision slide).

GLOSSARY

Plan: the Q2 2026 plan column of the source.

Attainment: Q2 actual ÷ Q2 plan, as a percent.

Gap closed: the share of the Q1-to-plan gap covered in Q2.

pp: percentage points, the change in a percentage metric.

x: pipeline coverage multiple; basis not stated.

Implied gross profit: revenue × gross margin (derived).

Source: quarterly_metrics.csv (synthetic), its data dictionary and the calculation outputs (private working repository).